



Et tu, brutus?

be the subject of attention from both the governments and users. To which of these parties Google has demonstrated more loyalty is something that's still not clear.

Yahoo has also been caught up in the web of privacy infringement and why not? After all, its main website and its services are one of the most popular globally only surpassed by the juggernaut that is Google. Yahoo was also one of the big names mentioned in the leaked documents as one of the companies that have allegedly handed over users' personal data to the NSA on a silver platter. Yahoo

Tracking India

So, where does all of this leave us here in India? Since India is the fifth most tracked country by the NSA according to the Snowden leaks, using most of the popular online services is something like a double-edged sword for you. First, your personal data is as much at risk as anyone else in the US, and second, as per the policy followed by the NSA and its paymasters, you don't have any rights to privacy especially when the American government comes into the picture. While all the companies we've mentioned ear-

lier have iterated over and over again that they do not provide information to the US government at the drop of a hat, you have to realise that most of this data gathering process is still wrapped under layers and layers of institutionalized secrecy.

The only real choices that you do have is to- a) trust the Googles, the Facebooks, the Microsofts and the Yahoos of the world b) or opt out of using any of these services, which is almost an unthinkable act in this day and age, c) or resign yourself to the idea that there will always be the risk of your private data being viewed by someone else overseas, d) or simply refrain from using the Internet when it comes to highly personal or private data.

Now, as if this story wasn't depressing so far, this is not the only thing that you've got to worry about, if you care about online privacy. The Indian government has also taken a shine to online surveillance and has in place processes through which it has an unimaginable potential to monitor almost 100% of the web traffic that flows in and out of our shores. This it does with the help of LIM (Lawful Intercept and Monitoring) systems that have been deployed at the primary gateway nodes of the major Indian ISPs, through which all of India's Internet traffic is routed to and from the rest of the world. By being the only ones controlling and maintaining these LIMs, the Indian

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has, of course, denied those allegations just like Google and Microsoft and has in fact sued the US government so that the company can make it clearer to its users about what it's sharing with the government. Facebook seems to be in a similar boat, accused of being lax with the personal information of its billion strong userbase while denying that it has gone out of its way to help do that.



Google Co-founders Larry Page and Sergey Brin (AP Photo/Paul Sakuma)